

Pri Existentials

1 Introduction

Li **existential construction** es un important tip de expression in li lingue, e sovente have complicat detallies de su usage e diachronic orígene. Yo va tractar li construction in su general filosofic rol, poy, li manieres per queles modern idiomas (precipue anglés e li romanice idiomas) expresse li existential construction, e concluder con remarcas pri li lingue international e li debate del existentielle de Occidental/Interlingue.

2 Li Existentielle

Un existential frase o declaration es un quel asserte que alquó existe, por exemple: “There is a tree in the courtyard.” o “Il y a deux chevaux dans les étables.”. It coresponde al existential quantificator ($\exists$) del logica. Sin merser se in li detallies del logica, on posse dir que ti quantificator asserte que adminim un cose in li monde del sistema satisfa li sequent conditiones. Li anglesi frase posse esser traductet al logica talmen:

$$\exists x : \text{Tree}(x) \wedge \text{In}(x, y) \wedge \text{Courtyard}(y)$$

Ma per quó un parlator deve expresser ti idé, e quálmen it contrasta al altri simil expressiones? Considera li differentie inter “There is a tree in the courtyard.”, “A tree is in the courtyard.”, “A tree stands in the courtyard.”, “A tree exists in the courtyard.”. Del pragmatic perspective (de quel on considera li plen contextu, e questiona pro quo li parlator selectet li paroles queles il selectet), li *there is* construction es li max basic, **inmarcat** forme, probabilmén li max natural forme quel un parlator de anglés vell dir. Un particulari contextu deve esser introductet por instigar li usation de un altri option, por exemple: si li parlator vole expresser que li corte ne es vacui, il posse dir “A tree is in the courtyard.”, o si il vole expresser que li storm ne ha removet omni árbor, il posse dir “A tree stands in the courtyard.”, o si il es in un filosofic discussion, il posse dir “A tree exists in the courtyard.”. Ma ancor li differenties es minori, e contextu e emfase posse furnir li necessari signification al just “There is a tree in the courtyard.”. Un trate comun al constructiones queles noi va studiar es que li expression del existentielle es sempre expreset ye li comense del frase, ante li nominale de quel it affirma li existentie (quel yo va nominar li **existor**). Temes e indicadores del structura del discourse es sovente talmen inicial.

Si on ne da un qualification al existentielle, it posse semblar innatural. Considera “There is a tree.”. Sin contextu, to es un strangi declaration. Litteralmen, esque

The **existential construction** is an important type of expression in language, and often has complicated details of usage and diachronic origin. I will treat the construction in its general philosophic role, then the ways in which modern languages (chiefly English and the Romance languages) express the existential construction, and conclude with remarks about the international language and the debate on the existential in Occidental/Interlingue.

An existential phrase or statement is one which asserts that something exists, for example: “There is a tree in the courtyard.”, or “Il y a deux chevaux dans les étables.”. It corresponds to the existential quantifier ($\exists$) of logic. Without plunging into the details of logic, one could say that this quantifier asserts that at least one thing in the world of the system satisfies the following conditions. The English phrase could be translated into logic as follows:

But how can a speaker express this idea, and how does it contrast with other similar expressions? Consider the difference between “There is a tree in the courtyard.”, “A tree is in the courtyard.”, “A tree stands in the courtyard.”, “A tree exists in the courtyard.”. From the pragmatic perspective (from which one considers the full context, and asks why the speaker chose the words they did), the *there is* construction is the most basic, **unmarked** form, probably the most natural form that a speaker of English would use. A particular context must be given to trigger the use of another option, for instance if the speaker wants to express that the courtyard is not empty, they might say “A tree is in the courtyard.”, or if they want to express that the storm has not removed all of the trees, they might say “A tree stands in the courtyard.”, or if they are in a philosophical discussion, they might say “A tree exists in the courtyard.”. But the differences are still small, and context and emphasis can fill in the necessary meaning to just “There is a tree in the courtyard.”. A common trait of the constructions that we will study is that the expression of the existential is always expressed at the beginning of the sentence, before the nominal that it is affirming the existence of (which I will call the **exister**). Themes and indicators of the structure of discourse are often initial like this.

If one does not give a qualification to an existential, it can seem unnatural. Consider “There is a tree.”. Without context, that’s a strange statement. Literally, does it

it significa que adminim un árbol existe in realitá? Ma to es naturalmen evident! Naturalmen, suficient conversational contextu posse far it natural, imagina si un person dit it quam un response a “There is nothing to hide behind in this courtyard!”. Ma in filosofic discussiones, quelcvez li litteral, completmen general signification **es** util (considera “There is a God.”).

3 Anglés

In anglés, li existential construction es li grammaticalmen confusent *there is*. Mult interessant fenomenes nasce ex to.

3.1 Conjugation

Li anglesi construction posse aparir in mult formes, por exemple: *there is*, *there are*, *there was*, *there were*, sequent li normal conjugation del verbe *to be*. Adplu, on posse usar li complex sistema de auxiliares normalmen, por exemple: *there will be*, *there would have been being*, *there can be*, *there should have been*. Quande on considera it profundmen, on decovri que ti construction es tre flexibil, exemples con altri verbes quam *there is able to be*, *there could exist*, *there will occur* suggeste que un plu general fenomen es present.

3.2 Vacui Subjectes

Ti fenomen es quelcvez descrit talmen: *there* es un “dummy subject” (Un satisfant traduction de *dummy* ne existe, ma fòrsan *simulacro*, *atrappe*, o *loc-tenant* es possibil. Yo va usar li adjective *vacui* e plu technicalmen *expletiv*. Un **expletive** posse quelcvez esser un maledition, ma ti sense veni del original signification de *plenator*). To relate al fenomen de “dummy *it*”, quel es comparabil. In alcun idiomas (hispan, italian), on posse ne dir li pronominal subjecte (un qualità nominat “pro-drop”, quasi “pronomin-lassant”). Vice “Lui parla italiano.” (“Il parla italian.”), on di “Parla italiano.”. Qui fa li verbe es evident del conjugation e contextu. To es tre util in un situation quande li verbe ne have un actor qui fa it, un **impersonal** verbe. Por dir que pluvie cade, in li hispan, on posse dir simplicmen “Llueve.”.

Con egard al idiomas queles **ne** have ti pro-drop habilitá, un subjecte deve esser dit. Quande li verbe es impersonal, un pronomine vacui, quel ne significa un person o cose, deve esser ancor usat. Por exemple, li francesi traduction del hispan “Llueve.” es “Il pleut.”. Anglés normalmen usa “it” quam vacui pronomine, vi li exemples: “It’s raining.”, “It is true that I saw you.”, “It was you that I saw!”, “It’s Monday.”, “It’s good to see you!”.

Fòrsan, *there* posse anc esser un tal vacui subjecte. Vice dir “A tree is in the courtyard.”, on posse di “There is a tree in the courtyard.”. Sintacticmen, on posse dir que li Nóminal Frase “a tree” move se, e junte al Prepositional Frase “in the courtyard” (Alcun sintaticos vell dir que ili deveni un “Small Clause”, ma li natura de ti junction

mean that at least one tree exists in reality? But that’s obvious! Naturally, sufficient conversational context can make it natural, imagine if a person says it in response to “There is nothing to hide behind in this courtyard!”. But in philosophical discussions, sometimes the literal, completely general meaning **is** useful (consider “There is a God.”).

In English, the existential construction is the grammatically confusing *there is*. Many interesting phenomena arise from this.

The English construction can appear in many forms, for example: *there is*, *there are*, *there was*, *there were*, following the normal conjugation of the verb *to be*. In addition, one can use the complex system of auxiliaries normally, for example: *there will be*, *there would have been being*, *there can be*, *there should have been*. When you considers it deeply, you find that the construction is very flexible, examples with other verbs like *there is able to be*, *there could exist*, *there will occur* suggest that a more general phenomenon is present.

This phenomenon is sometimes described like this: *there* is a “dummy subject”. (A satisfying translation for *dummy* doesn’t exist, but perhaps *simulacro*, *atrappe*, or *loc-tenant* would work. I will use the adjective *empty* and more technically *expletive*. An **expletive** can sometimes mean a swear word, but this sense comes from the original meaning of *filler*). This relates to the phenomenon of “dummy *it*”, which is comparable. In some languages (Spanish, Italian), you can not say the pronominal subject (a quality named “pro-drop”, from “pronoun-dropping”). Instead of “Lui parla italiano.” (“He speaks italian.”), one says “Parla italiano.”. Who does the verb is evident from the conjugation and context. This is very useful in a situation when the verb doesn’t have an actor who performs it, an **impersonal** verb. To say that rain falls, in Spanish one can say simply “Llueve.”.

For the languages which **don’t** have this pro-drop ability, a subject must be said. When the verb is impersonal, a dummy pronoun, which doesn’t refer to any person or thing, must still be used. For example, the French translation of Spanish “Llueve.” is “Il pleut.”. English normally uses “it” as a dummy pronoun, see the examples: “It’s raining.”, “It is true that I saw you.”, “It was you that I saw!”, “It’s Monday.”, “It’s good to see you!”.

Maybe *there* can also be such a dummy pronoun. Instead of saying “A tree is in the courtyard.”, one can say “There is a tree in the courtyard.”. Syntactically, one could say that the Noun Phrase “a tree” has moved, and joined with the Prepositional Phrase “in the courtyard” (Some syntacticians would say that they become a “Small

ne es important), e li expletive *there* vicea it, plenante position del subjecte quel deve ne esser vacui.

3.3 Li Órdine de Paroles

Ti analise explica pro quo on posse usar altri verbes ultra *to be*, e li similitá inter li du constructiones “There is *x*...” e “*x* is...”. Ma quo pri lu diacronic, lu historic? Clar information pri ancian idiomas es rar, ma on posse suggeste un origine de ti construction.

Old anglés (li idioma del anglo-saxones ante li normannic conquiste de Anglia) havet plu liber órdine de paroles quam hodie, ma generalmen it sequet li órdine **V2**, quel modern idiomas quam german ancor have. Por simplicimen descrire, V2 significa que li verbe es sempre li duesim del componentes. Si li subjecte es li unesim, li verbe seque it, quam in modern anglés. Ma si un altri frase es movet al comense, li verbe ancor seque ti unesim frase. Pro to, si un Prepositional Frase es li unesim frase, on di li verbe ante que on di li subjecte (dunc vice “In the courtyard, a man climbs a tree.”, on di “In the courtyard, climbs a man a tree.”.)

Dunc, un possibil hipotese es que li structura in quel *there* occupa li position del subjecte es un re-analise del structura in quel *there* es un simplic locativ adverbie movet al comense. Que li verbe concorda con li pluralitá del sequent existor es un problema por ti hipotese, pro que secun mult theories del sintaxe, li verbe posse concordar con solmen li subjecte, e noi ha dit que *there* es li subjecte. Ma *there*, pro que it es un inusual, expletiv pronómine, on posse dir que fórsan it ne have grammatical númere in alqual maniere. Un altri facte por consideration es que in quelc dialectes e variationes de anglés, inconcordantie es permissit: esque “There’s two trees in the courtyard.” es grammatical? It ne es incomprendibil, e por quelc parlatores it es un completmen grammatical e natural cose por dir. To indica que on posse haver diferent structuras de ti construction; fórsan li concordant regul es un vestigie del original structura preservet in mult educat, formal parlacion, ma ne sempre retenet in vulgari parlacion. Sin egard a ti debate, noi nu comprende plu profundmen li anglesi existential construction, e posse comparar it a ti de altri idiomas.

4 Li Romanic Idiomias

4.1 Francés

Li francesi existentiale es simil a ti de anglés, benque it usa li verbe por *haver* (*avoir*) vice ti por *esser* (*être*). Adplu, francés usa su normal expletiv pronómine *il* (que posse significa *é it é il*)—vide “Il pleut.”—quam vacui subjecte, in vice de transformar li locativ adverbie a un pronómine, quam li analise de vulgari anglés. Dunc, su construction es *il y a*, a saver: *it ta have/ha*. Li *a* conjuga se quasi normalmen, ma it es sempre singulari. To

Clause”, but the nature of this joining isn’t important), and the expletive *there* replaces it, filling the subject position which mustn’t be empty.

This analysis explains why one can use other verbs beyond *to be*, and the similarity between the two constructions “There is *x*...” and “*x* is...”. But what about the diachronic, the historical? Clear information about ancient languages is rare, but one can suggest an origin for this construction.

Old English (the language of the Anglo-Saxons before the Norman Conquest of England) had more free word order than today, but generally it followed **V2** order, which modern languages like German still have. To describe it simply, V2 means that the verb is always the second of the components. If the subject is first, the verb follows it, like in Modern English. But if another phrase is moved to the beginning, the verb still follows this first phrase. Thus, if a Prepositional Phrase is the first phrase, one says the verb before one says the subject (thus instead of “In the courtyard, a man climbs a tree.”, one says “In the courtyard, climbs a man a tree.”.)

Therefore, one possible hypothesis is that the structure in which *there* occupies the position of the subject is a reanalysis of the structure in which *there* is a simple locative adverb moved to the beginning. That the verb agrees with the plurality of the following exister is a problem for this hypothesis, because according to many theories of syntax, the verb can only agree with the subject, and we have said that *there* is the subject. But *there*, since it is an unusual, expletive pronoun, one could say that perhaps it doesn’t have grammatical number in the same way. Another factor to consider is that in some dialects and varieties of English, disagreement is permitted, is “There’s two trees in the courtyard” grammatical? It isn’t incomprehensible, and for some speakers it is a completely grammatical and natural thing to say. This indicates that one can have different structures of this construction, perhaps the agreement rule is a vestige of the original structure preserved in much educated, formal speech, but not always retained in vernacular speech. Regardless of this debate, we now understand more deeply the English existential construction, and can compare it to that of other languages.

es pro que grammaticalmen, li verbe *a* deve concordar a su subjecte que es li singulari *il*, ma li anglesi verbe es permisset concordar al existir (adminim in li educat anglési standardi).

Generalmen, ti construction functiona normalmen, it have li infinitiv forme *y avoir*, e li subjecte e verbe posse inverter se: “Il pleut.” → “Pleut-il ?”, “Il y a un arbre.” → “Y a-t-il un arbre ?”. On posse ignorar li *-t-* quel es insertet pro eufonie, li important idé es que li verbal frase *y a* move se al comense por indicar li interrogative.

Un remarca pri etimologie: li locativ pronómine *y* descende del latin *hīc*, con influentie de *ibī*. Ti du latin paroles es li genitores del parol usat in li existenciales de omni romanice idiomas de Francia e Iberia, quam va esser monstrat.

4.2 Catalan

Structuralmen, li catalan existenciale es tre simil a ti de francés, ma francés ne permesse li omission del pronómines (“pro-drop”). Catalan, ye li altri látere, permesse it, quam hispan e altri dialectes del sudic Francia. Dunc, on di “Hi ha un arbre.”, e li infinitive es *haver-hi*.

4.3 Hispan

Hispan difere de ti structura pro que it sembla har incorporat li locativ *ý* in li verbe. Vice “Ý ha un árbol.”, on di “Hay un árbol.”. *Hay* es re-analisat quam un special conjugat forme de *haber* quel es usat vice li normal *ha* solmen si it es ípersonal. Adplu, in li íperfect (passatic) forme, li *ý* desapari, li normal conjugation del verbe es usat: “Había un árbol.”. Dunc si noi ignora li diacronie, noi posse dir que hispan have un verbe *haber* quel, ínter altri functiones, expresse li existenciale quande usat ípersonalmen.

4.4 Italian

Italian es alquant diferent del altris de ti egard, e coincidentmen simil ad anglés. Li infinitive es dit *esserci*—observa que *essere* es li verbe usat, ne *avere*. On di “C’è un albero.”. Li particul *ci* (*c’è* es abreviat del *ci è*) es un locative de obscur orígine, ma possibilmen de *hīc*. Quam anglés standardi e ne quam francés o hispan, li verbe concorda con li existir (“C’è un albero, ci sono due alberi.”). Italian nequande havet li germanic V2 ór-dine, ma ti structura ne es tro strangi, pro que italian sovente have tal **clíticos** quam *cí*, *ví*, *ne*, *lo*, queles ímediatmen precede li verbe talmen, e li idioma anc posse mover li Verbal Frase al comense e fa it preceder li subjecte. Por exemple, on posse dir “È cresciuto l’albero.” vice “L’albero è cresciuto.” (“Li árbol ha crescet.”). Un tal forme es un marcat ór-dine, ma permisset por emfasar li verbe, e ergo on posse vider “C’è un albero.” quam un transformat forme de “Un albero c’è.”, e *un albero* resta li subjecte del verbe pos ti transformation, ne *ci*.

it is always singular. That is because grammatically, the verb *a* must agree with its subject which is the singular *il*, but in English the verb is permitted to agree with the exister (at least in the educated Standard English).

Generally, this construction functions normally, it has the infinitive form *y avoir*, and the subject and verb can invert: “Il pleut.” → “Pleut-il ?”, “Il y a un arbre.” → “Y a-t-il un arbre ?”. You can ignore the *-t-* which is inserted for euphony, the important idea is that the verbal phrase *y a* moves to the beginning to indicate the interrogative.

A remark on etymology: the locative pronoun *y* descends from Latin *hīc*, with influence from *ibī*. These two Latin words are the parents of the word used in existentials in all Romance languages of France and Iberia, as shall be shown.

Structurally, the Catalan existential is very similar to that of French, but French does not permit the omission of pronouns (“pro-drop”). Catalan, on the other hand, permits it, like Spanish and other dialects of southern France. Therefore, one says “Hi ha un arbre.”, and the infinitive is *haver-hi*.

Spanish differs from this structre because it seems to have incorporated the locative *ý* into the verb. Instead of “Ý ha un árbol.”, one says “Hay un árbol.”. *Hay* is reanalysed as a special conjugated form of *haber* which is used instead of the normal *ha* only if it is impersonal. Furthermore, in the imperfect (past) form, the *ý* disappears, the normal conjugation of the verb is used: “Había un árbol.”. Therefore, if one ignores the diachrony, we can say that Spanish has a verb *haber* which, among other functions, expresses the existential when used impersonally.

Italian is somewhat different from the others in this regard, and coincidentally similar to English. The infinitive is said *esserci*—observe that *essere* is the verb used, not *avere*. One says “C’è un albero.”. The particle *ci* (*c’è* is abbreviated from *ci è*) is a locative of obscure origin, but possibly from *hīc*. Like Standard English, and not like French or Spanish, the verb agrees with the exister (“C’è un albero, ci sono due alberi.”). Italian never had the Germanic V2 order, but this structure is not too strange, because Italian often has such **clitics** like *cí*, *ví*, *ne*, *lo*, which immediately precede the verb like this, and the language can also move the Verb Phrase to the beginning and make it precede the subject. For example, one can say “È cresciuto l’albero.” instead of “L’albero è cresciuto.” (“The tree has grown.”). Such a form is a marked order but permitted to emphasize the verb, and so one can see “C’è un albero.” as a tranformed form of “Un albero c’è.”, and *un albero* stays the subject of the verb after this transformation, not *ci*.

5 Altri Idiomias

5.1 German

German usa su verbe por *dar* (*geben*), con un impersonal vacui pronómin *es*, del sam origine quam anglés *it*. “Es gibt einen Baum.” litteralmen traducte se a “It da un árbol.”, observa que li existor *einen Baum* es acusativ; it es li objecte del verbe. Altri verbes quam *sein* (*esser*) e *stehen* (*star*) es anc usat, usualmen con *es* o *da* (*ta*).

5.2 Russ

Li existentiale de russ e altri slavic idiomias es simil a ti de italian, it usa li verbe *byt'* (*esser*) o *imét'sja* (aproximativmen *haver se*). On posse dir “Est' derevo.” (litteralmen “Es un árbol.”) o metter un locativ pronómine o prepositional qualification ante li *est'*: “Tam est' derevo.” (“Ta es un árbol.”). Li existor es in li nominativ casu, e li verbe ya concorda con su númere, si on egarda li futuri formes in queles númere es visibil: “Budet derevo.”, “Budut derev'ja.”, dunc noi conclude que li existor es li subjecte del verbe, quel es movet al comense por marcar li existentiale.

5.3 Esperanto

Esperanto (e Ido) usa su verbe por *esser* (*esti*), sin un expletive o locative: “Estas arbo.”. Observa que li verbe precede li existor. Li substantive es nominativ, ma on ne posse save li concordantie pro que *estas* es é li singulari é plural forme.

6 Consequentias por Interlingue

Li existentiale de Occidental/Interlingue es dominantmen li quasi-particul-quasi-verbe *hay*, prendet directmen ex hispan quam li particul *esque*, quel es prendet ex francés. Su usage in basic formes es simplic: “Hay un árbol in li corte.”, ma quó pri conjugation e li ordine del paroles? Si on vole traducter li anglés “There will be a tree in the courtyard.”, *esque* on posse dir “Va hay un árbol in li corte.”? Si yes, *esque hay* es un verbe, un irregulari forme quam *es* de *esser*? E si on vole traducter “There was a tree in the courtyard.”, nu on besona un conjugation del passate—*hayet*, *hayat*? E pro quo li parol sta ye li comense del frase, si it es un verbe? Un solution posse *esser* creat, ma it ne es completmen satisfatori.

Noi posse usar li saventie del europian lingues de nor viage in supra, e imaginar un etimologic forme quam *har-y*: “Ha(-)y un árbol.”, “Hat-y un árbol.”, “Por har-y un árbol.”, “Yo pensat que vell har-y un árbol.”. Grammaticalmen, noi have un regulari verbe con li plenitá de formes, sin li artificialitá de *hayar*. Alternativmen, noi posse sequer italian e anglés, fórsan: “Ta es un árbol.”, “Ta esset un árbol.”, “Por ta *esser* un árbol.” (o “Por *esser* ta un árbol.”?), “Yo pensat que ta vell *esser* un árbol”. Ma li detallies del ordine ne es clar ci. Dunc li

German uses its verb for *to give* (*geben*) with an impersonal dummy pronoun *es*, from the same origin as English *it*. “Es gibt einen Baum.” literally translates to “It gives a tree.”, observe that the exister *einen Baum* is accusative; it is the object of the verb. Other verbs like *sein* (*to be*) e *stehen* (*to stand*) are also used, usually with *es* or *da* (*there*).

The existential of Russian and other Slavic languages is similar to that of Italian, it uses the verb *byt'* (*to be*) o *imét'sja* (roughly *to have oneself*). One can say “Est' derevo.” (literally “Is a tree.”) or put a locative pronoun or prepositional qualification before the *est'*: “Tam est' derevo.” (“There is a tree.”). The exister is in the nominative case, and the verb does agree with its number, if one looks at the future forms in which number is visible: “Budet derevo.”, “Budut derev'ja.”, so we conclude that the exister is the subject of the verb, which is moved to the beginning to mark the existential.

Esperanto (and Ido) uses its verb for *to be* (*esti*) without an expletive or locative: “Estas arbo.”. Observe that the verb precedes the exister. The noun is nominative, but one cannot know the agreement because *estas* is both the singular and plural form.

The existential of Occidental/Interlingue is dominantly the almost-particle-almost-verb *hay*, taken directly from Spanish like the particle *esque* which was taken from French. Its usage in basic forms is simple: “Hay un árbol in li corte.”, but what about conjugation and word order? If one wants to translate the English “There will be a tree in the courtyard.”, can one say “Va hay un árbol in li corte.”? If yes, is *hay* a verb, an irregular form like *es* from *esser*? And if one wants to translate “There was a tree in the courtyard”, now one needs a past conjugation—*hayet*, *hayat*? And why does the word come at the beginning of the sentence, if it is a verb? A solution can be created, but it is not completely satisfactory.

We can use the knowledge of European languages from our above journey, and imagine an etymological form like *har-y*: “Ha(-)y un árbol.”, “Hat-y un árbol.”, “Por har-y un árbol.”, “Yo pensat que vell har-y un árbol.”. Grammatically, we have a regular verb with the fullness of forms, without the artificiality of *hayar*. Alternatively, we could follow Italian and English, perhaps: “Ta es un árbol.”, “Ta esset un árbol.”, “Por ta *esser* un árbol.” (o “Por *esser* ta un árbol.”?), “Yo pensat que ta vell *esser* un árbol”. But the details of order are't clear

possibilitás va esser discusset.

6.1 Expletives

Esque Occidental/Interlingue es pro-drop? Diferent stiles existe, é “It es ver que yo videt te.” é “Es ver que yo videt te.” es imaginabil e quelcvez trovat. Li Grammatica de Haas di: “Ye li impersonal verbes li pronómin *it* posse esser omisset, si li sens permesse to.”. Ma mult paratores ne omisse *it*, e sempre di *it es*. Dunc noi have du possibilitás—e devenir completmen pro-drop es absurd, omisser personal pronómines vell diminuer li claritá del idioma.

Sequente Haas, noi have un quasi innatural habilitá de omisser solmen li impersonal *it*, e ne li habilitá de omisser quelcunc altri pronómine o omisser *it* quande it refere se ad un objecte. Ti regul vell permesse li unesim supra idé de *har-y*: li francesi *il y a* deveni *it y ha* o *it ha y*, e noi posse omisse li *it* por haver li catalanesc *y ha* o hispanesc *ha y*. Li grammatical subjecte del verbe es li omisset impersonal pronómin, ma Occidental/Interlingue ne have un conjugativ diferentie ínter singulari e plural, e pro to ti grammatical detallie ne es important. Li problema que reste es li órdine, e fórsan li frontieres del paroles (*ha y*, *ha-y*, *hay*). Rememora anc que in italian (e russ e standardi anglés), un expletive ne es necessari pro que li existor es li subjecte. Dunc noi posse sive ne usar un expletive, sive usar quam un expletive *it*, un omisset *it*, o un altri parol, fórsan un locative si noi seque li analise de angés in quel *there* es un subjecte (ma to es probabilmen índesirat).

6.2 Locatives

Quó es ti nov parol *y*? Un trate que li supra existentials sovente have es haver un locative con li verbe. Si noi fracte *hay*, noi posse vicear it per just *y* con li verbe *har*. Ma introducter un nov particul *y* es índesirat, esque noi posse usar un existent parol quam *ci* or *ta*? Noi ya posse far to. Anglés usa su distant demonstrative *there* vice su proxim demonstrative *here*, ma li distinction ne es tam clar con egard al romanic *y*, *ci*. Dunc noi have ci quin possibilitás del locative: *ci*, *ta*, *y* (o aquel altri nov parol), e nequó.

6.3 Verbes

Pri li verbe, noi posse sive usar *esser* (sequente italian e anglés) o *har/haver* (sequente li altri romanic idiomas). Probabilmen, noi ne vole usar un altri verbe (por exemple li germanesc *dar*). Li natural romanic lingues ne have un distinction ínter *har* e *haver*, ma on posse arguer que pro su grammatical natura (e pro su brevitá), *har* es plu bon quam *haver*. *Exister* es anc possibil, ma it ne es li tip de verbe apt por un special discourse-grammatical construction, it expresse existentie litteralmen.

6.4 Órdines

Noi ancor have li problema del position del paroles. Li relativ órdine del locative e verbe ne es important, adver-

here. Therefore the possibilities will be discussed.

Is Occidental/Interlingue pro-drop? Different styles exist, both “It es ver que yo videt te.” e “Es ver que yo videt te.” are imaginable and sometimes found. The Grammatica de Haas says: “With the impersonal verbs, the pronoun *it* can be omitted, if the sense permits.”. But many speakers don’t omit it, and always say *it es*. Therefore we have two possibilities—and becoming completely pro-drop is absurd, to omit personal pronouns would diminish the clarity of the language.

Following Haas, we have an almost unnatural ability to omit only the impersonal *it*, and not the ability to omit any other pronoun or to omit *it* when it refers to an object. This rule would permit the first above idea of *har-y*: the French *il y a* becomes *it y ha* or *it ha y*, and we can omit the *it* to have the Catalan-like *y ha* or Spanish-like *ha y*. The grammatical subject of the verb is the omitted impersonal pronoun, but Occidental/Interlingue does not have a conjugative difference between singular and plural, and so this grammatical detail is not important. The problem that remains is the order, and perhaps the border of the words (*ha y*, *ha-y*, *hay*). Remember also that in Italian (and Russian and Standard English), an expletive is not necessary because the exister is the subject. Therefore we can either not use an expletive, or use as an expletive *it*, an omitted *it*, or another word, perhaps a locative if we follow the analysis of English in which *there* is a subject (but that is probably undesirable).

What is this new word *y*? A trait which the above existentials often have is to having a locative with the verb. If we break up *hay*, we can replace it with just *y* with the verb *har*. But to introduce a new particle *y* is undesirable, can we use an existing word like *ci* or *ta*? We can indeed. English uses its distant demonstrative *there* instead of its close demonstrative *here*, but the distinction is less clear with the Romance *y*, *ci*. So we have here five possibilities of the locative: *ci*, *ta*, *y* (or some other new word), and nothing.

For the verb, we can either use *esser* (following Italian and English) or *har/haver* (following the other Romance languages). Probably, we do not want to use another verb (for example the German-like *dar*). The natural Romance languages do not have a distinction between *har* and *haver*, but one could argue that because of its grammatical nature (and because of its brevity), *har* is better than *haver*. *Exister* is also possible, but it is not the type of verb appropriat for a special discourse-grammatical construction, it expresses existence literally.

We still have the problem of the position of the words. The relative order of the locative and verb is not impor-

bies ja posse sive preceder sive sequer li verbe. Ma confusion ínter expletives e locatives es facil, egarda li diferentie ínter anglés e italian. Secun li analise in supra, noi save li fundamental diferentie. In anglés, *there* precede li verbe pro que it sive seque un vestigial V2-esc órdine sive es un re-analisat expletiv subjecte del verbe. In italian, *ci* precede li verbe pro que to es li normal órdine de un clítico, un romanice trate quel Occidental/Interlingue ne have: Noi sempre di “Yo ama le.” vice li romanice “Io lo amo.”. Nor lingue ne have ni un historie de órdine V2 ni preverbal clíticos; it deve sempre haver strict órdine por facil comprension. Ci noi encontra un problema: un trate del existential contruccion es que ili sovente ne seque li normal órdine de lor idioma, ili es special, prominent contruccion. Si noi infortia li regulas del órdine, noi remove li special existentiale. Regarda li diferentie ínter li anglés “There is a tree.” e “A tree is there.”. Esque noi vole que li verbe comensa li frase? Si noi have un expletiv subjecte, it posse facilmen comensar it. Si noi di que li subjecte es li existor, noi vell dever crear un nov special regul de órdine por retener li prominent órdine de un existentiale.

7 Soluciones por Interlingue

Ve! Si noi multiplica ti optiones, noi vide que noi have adminim 60 possibilitás ($3_{\text{Expletives}} \times 5_{\text{Locatives}} \times 3_{\text{Verbes}} + 2_{\text{Órdines sin Expletive}} \times 5_{\text{Locatives}} \times 3_{\text{Verbes}}$). Nor resercha ha dat plu mult problemas quam solutiones, ma to es pro que noi ne pensa practicalmen.

7.1 Existent Solutiones

Quelc solutiones ha ja esset proposit. Noi posse continuar usar *hay* e ignorar li problema fundamental. Noi posse usar li improvisat *hayar*, quel on posse analizar quam un ínregulari verbe quel have un omisset subjecte e quel asserite que su objecte existe. Ya noi anc posse evitar *hay* per ne usar it. Observa que in li córpor de ti textu yo ha necú usat *hay*, ma in vice yo elabora li detallies de mi signification, e usa ja grammatical metodes quam *esser* e *existe*. Restrictiones de parlacion posse fortiar util reconsideration de Vor idé—filosoficmen, quó existentie vermen significa?

Alternativmen, noi posse sequer li solution de H. Littlewood. Il proposi “Es un árbol in li corte.”, a saver: usar *esser*, movet al comense. Ti solution es tre simil al italian metode, ma sin li locative *ci*. It ne necessita nov paroles, ma it ya necessita usar movement quel es normalmen evitat. Fórsan on posse admitter ti ínregularitá, quam yo observat supra, ti ínusual position es li marcatesse, li indicator de un conventionalisat structura: li existentiale.

Un conflicte es creat, támen, con li *it*-omission de Haas. Li paroles “Es un árbol.” posse significar “It es un árbol.” o “Un árbol es.”. Noi solmen have li órdine por

tant, adverbs already can either precede or follow the verb. But confusion between expletives and locatives is easy, look at the difference between English and Italian. According to the above analysis, we know the fundamental difference. In English, *there* precedes the verb because it either follows a vestigial V2 order or it is a reanalysed expletive subject of the verb. In Italian, *ci* precedes the verb because that is the normal order for a clitic, a Romance property which Occidental/Interlingue does not have: We always say “Yo ama le” instead of the Romance “Io lo amo.”. Our language does not have a history of V2 order nor preverbal clitics, it must always have strict order to have easy understanding. Here we encounter a problem: a property of the existential construction is that they often do not follow the normal order of their language, they are special, prominent constructions. If we enforce the rules of order, we remove the special existential. Regard the difference between the English “There is a tree.” and “A tree is there.”. Do we want the verb to begin the sentence? If we have an expletive subject, it can easily begin it. If we say that the subject is the exister, we would have to create a new special rule of order to retain the prominent order of the existential.

Alas! If we multiply these options, we see that we have at least 60 possibilities ($3_{\text{Expletives}} \times 5_{\text{Locatives}} \times 3_{\text{Verbes}} + 2_{\text{Órdines sin Expletive}} \times 5_{\text{Locatives}} \times 3_{\text{Verbes}}$). Our research has given more problems than solutions, but that is because we are not thinking practically.

Some solutions have already been proposed. We can continue to use *hay* and ignore the fundamental problem. We can use the improvised *hayar*, which one can analyse as an irregular verb that has an omitted subject and that asserts that its object exists. Indeed, we can also avoid *hay* by not using it. Observe that in the body of this text I have nowhere used *hay*, but instead I elaborate the details of my meaning, and use already grammatical methods like *esser* e *existe*. Restrictions of speech can force useful reconsideration of your ideas—philosophically, what does existence really mean?

Alternatively, we can follow the solution of H. Littlewood. He proposes “Es un árbol in li corte.”, that is: to use *esser*, moved to the beginning. This solution is very similar to the italian method, but without the locative *ci*. It doesnot need new words, but it actually needs to use movement that is normally avoided. Perhaps we can admit this irregularity, as I observed above, this unusual position is the markedness, the indicator of a conventionalized structure: the existential.

A conflict is created, however, with Haas’ *it*-omission. The words “Es un árbol.” can mean “It is a tree.” or “A tree is.”. We only have order to indicate the grammatical

indicar li grammatical structura, ma noi vole re-ordinar e omisser paroles por naturalitá, e dunc noi crea mal ambiguitás. Por ne simplicmen ignorar ti problema, noi deve rejecter sive Haas sive Littlewood.

7.2 Nov Solutiones

Si Vu vole luder, Vu posse scri usante mi *har-y* o un altri innovat sistema, e to vell esser interessant. Si Vu prefere sequer li natural idiomas, Vu posse usa un sistema que seque les (*har-y*, *y haver*, *ta esser*...). Si Vu prefere *a priori* grammatica, Vu posse usar un artificial particul quam *hay* o un nov stil de verbal usage (*star*, *har*).

Ma por li comunité, li expansion de un stil es important. Ferdinand de Saussure parlat pri li Invariabilitá del Signe, li idé que un parte del incorporal lingual sistema ne posse esser changeat de quelcunc individue. Pro que nor lingue es é artificial é have un micri parlatori comunité, modificar it es quasi possibil, ma ancor desfacil. Pro to, li modificationes deve esser minimal e natural.

Li suggestion de Littlewood es tal, parlatores ja reordina li paroles por emfisar alquó o subconscientmen sequer lor natal idioma. Anc it posse esser levimen adaptat, por exemple quelcvez usar *star* (un apt verbe infrequentmen usat) o *exister* vice *esser*, o adjunter un locative quam *ta*. E noi posse facilmen ignorar li remarca de Haas e sempre retener *it* por claritá.

Quocunc noi fa, un perfect e comun special forme por expresser li existentiale ne va existir, ma to es anc ver por li natural lingues. Li special constructiones queles yo discusset devet esser creat de existent paroles por to. Latin ne have un special construction, it solmen usat su verbe *esser* ("Arbor est."), e li modern lingues developat special formes e re-analises.

8 Conclusion

Yo ha discusset mult detallies pri existential constructiones in natural idiomas e poy mult detallies pri it in Occidental/Interlingue. Yo ne ha dat un sol solution, ma plutost dat mult idé e possibilitás. Si Vu desira scri histories e essayes per Occidental/Interlingue, considera chascun frase e qualmen it va semblar a Vor letores, e considera li stil quel Vu vole usar (antiqui, modern, formal, informal, romanic, germanic). Si Vu desira solmen conversar in un lingue facil e international, seque li convention de Vor circumité o innova un creativ maniere de parlar. Ultra to: "Ne hay plu."/"Ne es plu."/"Plu ne existe"/"Ta ne es plu."/"Y ne ha plu."/"Yo ne posse dir plu."

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structure, but we want to reorder and omit words for naturality, and so we create bad ambiguities. In order to not simply avoid this problem, we must reject either Haas or Littlewood.

If you want to play, you can write using my *har-y* or another innovated system, and that would be interesting. If you prefer to follow the natural languages, you can use a system that follows them (*har-y*, *y haver*, *ta esser*...). If you prefer *a priori* grammar, you can use an artificial particle like *hay* or a new stye of verbal usage (*star*, *har*).

But for the community, the spread of a style is important. Ferdinand de Saussure spoke of the Invariability of the Sign, the idea that a part of the incorporeal language system cannot be changed by any individual. Because our language is both artificial and has a small speaker community, modifying it is almost possible, but still difficult. Therefore, the modifications must be minimal and natural.

The suggestion of Littlewood is like this, speakers already reorder words to emphasize something or subconsciously follow their native language. Also it can be slightly adapted, for example to sometimes use *star* (an appropriate verb infrequently used) or *exister* instead of *esser*, or to adjoin a locative like *ta*. And we can easily ignore Haas' remark and always keep *it* for clarity.

Whatever we do, a perfect and common special form to express the existential will not exist, but that is also tue for natural languages. The special constructions that I discussed had to be created from existing words for that. Latin does not have a special construction, it only uses its verb *to be* ("Arbor est."), and the modern languages developed special forms and reanalyses.

I have discussed many details of the existential constructions in natural languages and then many details of it in Occidental/Interlingue. I have not given a single solution, but rather given many ideas and possibilities. If you desire to write stories and essays using Occidental/Interlingue, consider every phrase and what it will mean to your readers, and consider the stye which you want to use (old-fashioned, modern, formal, informal, Romance, Germanic). If you desire only to converse in an easy and international language, follow the convention of your environment or innovate a creative manner of speaking. Beyond that there is no more to say.

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